

Run Automated System Tasks WITH ANACRON

Periodic command scheduling is the main feature of Anacron, which, in contrast with Cron, does not assume that the system is running all the time. Anacron makes life easier by taking care of routine system tasks without having to specifically run them. Scheduled tasks are monitored by a system of notifications to the user or administrator of the system.

GNU/Linux provides a high degree of scripting and automation. Cron-like utilities have moved it up to the next level. They provide a cleaner way of executing tasks or jobs in an automated and repeated manner. So if Cron is such a great utility, what is the need for another utility like Anacron?

Cron is ideal for servers, i.e., it expects the system to run 24x7. If, for instance, you had configured a Cron job for 11:30 p.m. and, unfortunately, your system was not up at that time, your Cron job wouldn't run. If such occurrences take place often, many problems could arise like missing important software updates, regular maintenance activities, regular rotation of log files and so on. The final outcome would be that the system might not be up-to-date or might be in an inconsistent state. Wouldn't it be great if the system remembers when certain scheduled tasks have not been executed and does the needful when it comes up again? Well, Anacron does exactly that.

Anacron is also a task scheduling utility and it executes jobs periodically, with the frequency specified in days only. Since it does not expect the system to run 24 hours a day, it is ideal for laptops or desktops. Anacron ensures that a job that has not been executed due to the system being down, will be executed when the system comes up again. Please note that Anacron is a supplement to Cron and not its complete replacement.

Anacron does not run continuously like a daemon. It is